

IN CONTEXT

Ancient parallels

Alchemy gained strong roots in the West during medieval times, via diverse international influences that stretched back much earlier: alchemical concepts are found in the traditions of China (see p.51), India, Greece, Byzantium, and the Muslim world. Western alchemy owed much to Arabic ideas, many seemingly derived from a figure called Geber, a Western name used to refer both to Jabir ibn Hayyan (c. 700s)—traditionally hailed as an important Arabic alchemist—and to a later European author-alchemist.

This print from 1584 portrays Arabic alchemist Jabir ibn Hayyan.



The stages involved in trying to create the fabled Philosopher's Stone, also called the Great Work, varied in number and type. There were often either seven of them, as in the 16th-century *Splendor solis* (see below and pp.152–153), or 12, as in the *Twelve Keys* of Basil Valentine. Sets of numbers linked with symbols were all part of alchemy's secretly coded world, in which astrology figured large. Alchemical materials and processes were thought to be linked

with the numbers, nature, and workings of heavenly bodies, and the zodiac and astrological symbols were used widely. For example, one Renaissance-era system presented 12 “gates,” or stages, associated with the 12 zodiac signs, in the following order: Calcination (Aries); Congelation (Taurus); Fixation (Gemini); Solution (Cancer); Digestion (Leo); Distillation (Virgo); Sublimation (Libra); Separation (Scorpio); Ceration (Sagittarius); Fermentation (Capricorn); Multiplication (Aquarius); and Projection (Pisces).

Colorful progressions

Western alchemists pursuing the Stone wanted their laboratory processes to produce colors in a certain order. There were four stages, although some texts mentioned more. The “Nigredo” stage, linked with blackness, came first; then “Albedo,” the white; a third yellowing stage (less commonly mentioned), “Citrinitas”; and finally a fourth stage, “Rubedo,” identified by a purple or reddish color that meant the “red stone” had been successfully created.

The symbolism of alchemical texts was closely tied to these color progressions, so, for example, a crow might represent the Nigredo stage, or a peacock, with its stunning tail unfurled (see p.153), might represent a stage that aimed to bring about a dazzling array of colors.

As above, so below

Renaissance alchemists also owed much to Hermetic ideas (see pp.134–135), notably those found in a text called the “Smaragdine Tablet” or “Emerald

► Born again

Ideas of regeneration and resurrection ran throughout alchemy. In this image from *Splendor solis* (1500s), a crowned angel offers a cloth to a man rising from a dank swamp. His black and red coloration reflects two of the stages in the alchemical process.

